

PDF file name: Psy-2022-Racial Discrimination Distress Coping Motives

Original article word count: 4033

Extracted content word count: 1449 (35% of the original word count)

Title of the article: *Racial Discrimination, Distress, Coping Motives, and Alcohol-Related Problems Among U.S.-Born Asian American Young Adults*

The content extracted is as follows:

Given the numerous alcohol-related problems associated with heavy alcohol use including relationship problems, drinking and driving, and violence (Hingson et al., 2017), it is essential to identify the determinants and mechanisms that heighten alcohol-related problems among this highest risk group.

Other studies have identified subgroups of Asian American young adults who have comparable rates of heavy drinking and alcohol-related problems compared to other racial groups such as white Americans (Cook et al., 2013; Iwamoto et al., 2010).

Comprehensive reviews highlight the deleterious effects of racial discrimination on a wide range of health outcomes, including alcohol misuse, psychological distress, depression, and physical health problems (Pascoe & Smart Richman, 2009; Williams & Mohammed, 2009).

The paucity of studies that have included racial discrimination has found a direct association between discrimination and alcohol use and related problems among community samples of Asian Americans (Chae et al., 2008; Gee et al., 2007; Yoo et al., 2010).

This is a significant gap in the literature as discrimination gets under the skin heightening risk for alcohol-related problems (Hatzenbuehler, 2009; Hatzenbuehler et al., 2011).

While the positive relationship between psychological distress and alcohol-related problems is well-established (Merrill et al., 2014), the motive of drinking to cope may be a more proximal predictor of alcohol-related problems (Cooper et al., 2016; Rice & Van Arsdale, 2010).

College students who drink to cope with distress have been found to be at an increased risk of experiencing alcohol-related problems in comparison to those who drink for reasons consistent with positive reinforcement (e.g., social purposes or enhancement motives) even after controlling for alcohol consumption (Cox et al., 2006). While several studies have reported significant associations between psychological distress and alcohol use among Asian Americans (Cheng et al., 2012; Kim et al., 2014), fewer have investigated the role of severe, unavoidable, and uncontrollable stressors (such as, racism) that may confer risk for elevated levels of alcohol-related problems (Chae et al., 2008).

The theoretical mechanisms of risk (i.e., drinking to cope) between racial discrimination and alcohol-related problems among white and ethnic/racial minority college students were first tested by Hatzenbuehler et al. (2011).

Coping motives mediated the association between discrimination and alcohol-related problems.

The study suggested that college students' discrimination was indirectly linked to alcohol-related problems through negative affect and drinking to cope for both white and ethnic/racial minority students; however, this study did not disaggregate ethnic/racial minority groups.

To our knowledge, there have been no studies that have examined the degree to which racial discrimination has an indirect effect on alcohol-related problems through multiple mechanisms of risk including, psychological distress and drinking to cope, among U.S.-born Asian Americans.

One study examined how discrimination was indirectly associated with alcohol-related problems through drinking to cope among underage (under the legal drinking age; 18-year olds) Asian American college students (Le & Iwamoto, 2019).

To this end, the degree to which racial discrimination may indirectly operate through psychological distress which, in turn, may be associated with drinking to cope and alcohol-related problems, is still unknown.

This gap is significant as there is evidence to believe that the indirect effect of racial discrimination on alcohol-related problems may be stronger through psychological distress (Huynh et al., 2014; Syed & Juan, 2012).

Based on the negative reinforcement and motivational theoretical models and related empirical findings (Cooper et al., 2016; Kenney et al., 2015; Solomon & Corbit, 1974), we hypothesize that higher reported levels of racial discrimination, distress, and drinking to cope will be significantly associated with alcohol-related problems.

Second, we test the degree to which discrimination may have an indirect effect on alcohol-related problems through two mechanisms of risk: Psychological distress and drinking to cope. We hypothesize that discrimination will heighten distress, which will in turn relate to drinking to cope with motives, which will result in more alcohol-related problems.

Everyday Racial Discrimination (Williams et al., 1997)

The Rutgers Alcohol Problems Index (RAPI) examines the frequency at which an individual

experienced alcohol-related problems or negative consequences while or because of drinking over the past year.

The subscales were used as indicators/parcels of the latent factor of alcohol-related problems.

Data Analytic Plan

Following Martens et al. (2007) recommendations, the alcohol-related problems latent factor was created using alcohol abuse, personal problems, and social problems subscales.

Descriptive Data

The correlation analysis revealed that racial discrimination was positively associated with psychological distress ($r = .41$, $p < .001$), drinking to cope ($r = .20$, $p < .001$), and alcohol-related problems ($r = .22$, $p < .001$).

Psychological distress was positively related to drinking to cope ($r = .29$, $p < .001$) and alcohol-related problems ($r = .25$, $p < .001$), and drinking to cope was related to alcohol-related problems ($r = .62$, $p < .001$).

Measurement Model

The latent constructs in the measurement model, included discrimination, psychological distress, drinking to cope, and alcohol-related problems, were allowed to covary and provided adequate fit to the data ($\chi^2(71) = 281.69$, $p < .001$, CFI = .99, TLI = .98, and RMSEA = .046).

Structural Model

The significant pathways between factors and the R-square for psychological distress, drinking to cope, and alcohol-related problems latent factors are reported in Figure 1.

Controlling for alcohol consumption ($\beta = .32$, $p < .001$), Greek status ($\beta = .08$, $p < .001$), and gender ($\beta = .05$, $p = .07$), higher reports of racial discrimination ($\beta = .08$, $p < .001$), psychological distress ($\beta = .06$, $p < .05$), and drinking to cope ($\beta = .51$, $p < .001$), were positively associated with more alcohol-related problems (results are displayed in Figure 1).

The bootstrap bias-corrected standard errors, which included 1,000 bootstrapped samples tests of indirect effects, detected two indirect effects: (a) racial discrimination (.073, $p < .001$, 95% CI [.054, .093]) had an indirect effect on alcohol-related problems through psychological distress and drinking to cope, and (b) racial discrimination had an indirect effect on alcohol-related problems through psychological distress (.03, $p < .05$, 95% CI [.0005, .053]).

See Table 1. Asian Americans experience frequent racial discrimination yet there has been limited research that has investigated its relationship to alcohol-related problems.

The present study significantly advances the scant literature in this area by first, highlighting the direct and indirect associations between racial discrimination and alcohol-related problems, and second, identifying psychological distress and drinking to cope as potential mechanisms of risk.

Controlling for well-established covariates of problematic alcohol use among college students including, Greek status (Borsari et al., 2007), quantity of alcohol consumption and gender, racial discrimination was found to be directly associated with alcohol-related problems.

The direct effects of discrimination on alcohol use and alcohol-related problems are consistent with previous studies with community samples of Asian Americans (Chae et al., 2008; Gee et al., 2007; Yoo et al., 2010).

The second hypothesis was supported as well, wherein racial discrimination had an indirect relationship on alcohol-related problems through psychological distress and the drinking to cope motive.

Asian American college students in our study who experienced relatively higher frequencies of racial discrimination were more likely to report more distress and experience greater alcohol-related problems.

Based on motivational models (Cooper et al., 2016), it is plausible that racial discrimination heightens psychological distress, thus, these individuals may engage in problematic alcohol use to cope with and regulate their distress due to discrimination.

Findings add to growing evidence regarding the distinct and toxic role of racial discrimination on psychological distress and alcohol-related problems. Due to limitations attributable to the cross-sectional design of this study, it is difficult to definitively conclude the temporal direction and influence among the variables in the model (Maxwell & Cole, 2007).

Longitudinal design would be better suited to prospectively investigate the prognosis of alcohol-related problems and more accurately approximate the indirect effects of racial discrimination.

Additionally, this study builds upon previous investigations into the discrimination-alcohol problem relationship by testing the influence of two theoretically important mechanisms of risk, including drinking motive and distress.

Despite these limitations, the current study provides greater specificity regarding the distinct pathways through which discrimination gets under the skin (Hatzenbuehler, 2009) and confers risk for the development of alcohol-related problems for an underrepresented and overlooked group in the alcohol literature, U.S.-born Asian Americans.

Considering that racial discrimination seems pertinent to problematic drinking among this sample, it is important to assess, address, and validate the clients' racial discrimination experiences in clinical practice.

Clinically targeting the relevant mechanisms of risk (e.g., psychological distress and the drinking to cope motive) and providing alternative active coping strategies might also be facilitative in the reduction of alcohol-related problems.

Psychologists should also work with Asian American antiracist activists to think through and develop antiracism college programming for Asian American students with the goal of minimizing the corrosive impact of racism on distress and alcohol-related problems.